The Mental Health Epidemic: Trying to Fight a Broken System With Music

Research Question: In what ways does Wilbur Soot utilize his lyrics to convey the message that systematic ignorance perpetuates the mental health crisis?

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Introduction

The mental illness epidemic is one of the most disregarded issues in our society. Not only does mental illness lower the quality of life for the people directly affected by it, but it impacts the lives of friends, family members, and loved ones. Despite this, it is continuously overlooked, stigmatized, and ignored. In the United Kingdom, it's estimated that only 1 of 8 diagnosed patients receive any treatment ("How Common Are Mental Health Problems?"), not to mention the 36% of the population lacking a proper diagnosis. (Hazlegreaves) This purposeful ignorance perpetuates the mental health crisis, as elements like stressful societal culture and stigma fail to be addressed. This lack of awareness and the dire need for societal change is one of the topics that the musician Wilbur Soot tackles in his music. Soot, a British YouTuber and Twitch streamer, began writing and producing music in 2018, and quickly rose to fame with his witty internet presence and captivating music. He produced two albums, "Maybe I Was Boring" (2019) and "Your City Gave Me Asthma" (2020) independently, and in May of 2021, debuted his new band, Lovejoy, with their EP titled "Are You Alright?"

In October of 2021, Lovejoy released their second EP, "Pebble Brain", consisting of seven songs, most of which illustrated the similar musical aesthetic that the band had displayed previously. However, the sixth track on the album stood out to most long-term fans, as its lyrical style contained elements that were unmistakably nostalgic of his earlier independent albums. The track, titled "The Fall", called back to the message of purposeful ignorance towards mental health that Soot had continuously infused in his earlier works. It specifically parallels two of his songs from the album "Your City Gave Me Asthma": "Jubilee Line" and "I'm Sorry Boris".

Together, these three songs portrayed Soot's take on this very prominent issue and displayed to his audience his empathy and confliction for the subject, as a person who had personally experienced the harm and the ignorance that accompanied mental illness. Each song individually reflects the message through Soot's unique writing style, which frequently consists of literary devices such as repetition, parallelism, rhyme scheme, allusions, and more. His lyrics hint at his personal experiences with mental health and address the convoluted and ignorant approach that the leaders of our society have taken to solve this issue. These songs together demonstrate the prominence of mental illness and magnify how the same issues he wrote about in his independent works are still significantly prominent in the social structures that are still visible today. Soot utilizes these literary devices to produce music that analyzes Britain's mental health crisis and conveys the urgency for political change.

Body of the Essay

1. *The Fall*

Lovejoy's song, "The Fall" addresses one of the biggest issues concerning the mental health epidemic: ignorance. The lyrical imagery illustrates the burden of mental illness to the audience and conveys a sense of hopelessness and frustration as the narrator describes how society is being blinded by materialistic distractions. Soot evokes a feeling of regret and guilt as he portrays how mental illness is disregarded by others as they ignorantly gorge on materialistic goods, and insist that those suffering from mental illness should suppress their issues as they are deemed as not desirable. This mentality mimics the actions of our government leaders, as they paint idealistic standards of living and promote consumerism, actively attempting to encourage society into ignoring the undesirable aspects of human existence. Soot especially reflects this government and consumer relationship during the bridge of the song. The bridge refers to "ramblers" (Lovejoy 0:48) promoting the "marvelous" (Lovejoy 0:52) view from a building, in the same essence that a real estate agent points out the selling points of a property. It is then followed by the narrator referring to how the view has taken lives, indicating suicide, and how "they'll never know what you knew." (Lovejoy 0:58) The use of the word "ramblers" and the vague pronoun reference of "they'll" symbolizes this relationship to the audience, as it's unclear whether it represents an ignorant government or an uneducated citizen. The bridge is repeated a second time before the concluding verse of the song, with the same two sentences about the ramblers and the marvelous view being repeated at first. However, there's an antithesis in the structure, where Soot inserts the word "still", changing the lyric to, "it's still a marvelous view". (Lovejoy 1:49) By including the word "still" the second time, Soot directly displays this theme

of ignorance. He is indicating that the ramblers continue to promote the "view" regardless of the implications that are associated with it. These two sentences perfectly symbolize the message of how society's ignorance is continuing to perpetuate these mental health issues, as regardless of the destruction that these structures are causing, they continue to "never know what you knew." (Lovejoy 0:58)

The motifs of government ignorance and materialistic distractions continuously appear throughout his songs, however, this song specifically highlights how aspects of life are purposefully utilized to belittle the importance of the mental health crisis. One example of this is during the second verse, where Soot mentions leaving the "sink estates" (Lovejoy 0:34) and booking a "holiday." (Lovejoy 0:35) A sink estate is a British slang term for a housing development in a low-income area with high levels of social deprivation. The mentioning of "sink estates" identifies another important aspect of the mental health epidemic, which is how it influences low-income citizens and minorities more harshly. The Mental Health Act of 1983 indicates the procedures regarding diagnosis, treatment, and the rights of those with a mental disorder, ("Mental Health and The Law") however, it's been proven that the forceful detention aspect of the act has been disproportionately evoked towards Black citizens and minority groups. (Parkin et al) When Soot promptly follows the allusion to sink estates by writing, "let's book a holiday" (Lovejoy 0:35), he's directly displaying how society is purposefully ignoring some of the most prominent issues affecting minority groups by participating in idealistic greed. Another example of this is in the second appearance of the bridge, right before the final verse. Soot writes "The treadmill still looms / of your hedonic misuse." (Lovejoy 1:53-1:59) The inclusion of "hedonic" especially magnifies this idea, as hedonic is a polyseme, meaning both pleasant and

unpleasant. However, each definition wildly changes the meaning of this line, reiterating this internal debate of taking action or allowing yourself to be swept up in the encouraged idealistic perspective. Viewing hedonic as pleasant illustrates the idealistic perspective, one that's nicer for the audience to digest, a perspective of treadmills, Pelatons, exercise, and dieting, being a positive form of self-improvement. On the contrary, viewing hedonic as unpleasant reveals the darker parts of society to the audience, one that most people would be less keen to picture, a perspective of over-exercise, starvation, and unattainable beauty standards. While Soot spends a lot of time being frustrated towards those not taking action, he indicates his understanding of why some people don't take action, in these lines.

The final verse of this song is full of symbolic literary devices, but the most prominent is the rhyme scheme. The first two lines end with the end rhymes of “apathy” (Lovejoy 2:17) and “tapestry” (Lovejoy 2:21), followed by the next two lines having the slant rhyme of “species” (Lovejoy 2:25) and “to me.” (Lovejoy 2:29) However, the next three lines display not only a break in the AABB rhyme scheme but also a break from the previous, more accusatory, mentality that Soot illustrates throughout the final verse. The rhyme scheme for these lines is in an ACA pattern, with the final words being “mall” (Lovejoy 2:32), “effortful” (Lovejoy 2:35), and “fall.” (Lovejoy 2:40) The inclusion of the C element in the rhyme scheme indicates a stark contrast in this line compared to the rest of the verse, and the lyrics reflect this contrast as well. Throughout the verse, Soot criticizes the ignorance that he had conveyed earlier throughout the song, with lines like “see the apathy” (Lovejoy 2:16-2:18), and “the reems of gray stencils that fill the tapestry” (Lovejoy 2:19-2:21), which is a metaphor for the severe amount of infrastructure that's diminishing our “tapestry” or societal beauty. However, Soot introduces

another mentality during the C line, where he writes, “I would do something if it wasn’t all so effortful.” (Lovejoy 2:32-2:36) By highlighting this specific line by breaking the rhyme scheme, Soot reinforces how effective the method of disguising social injustices is in society by implying that his inability to take action makes him as bad as the people he is criticizing.

2. *Jubilee Line*

“Jubilee Line" is the first track on Wilbur Soot’s album, “Your City Gave Me Asthma”. With simple, repetitive lyrics, it emulates the remorse and anger that not only Soot, but countless people feel worldwide, as they watch governmental figures haphazardly and carelessly continue to disguise this issue with inadequate attempts to gain public satisfaction. The lyrics illustrate the same internal debates that are reflected in “The Fall", the frustration from feeling powerless and the feeling of selfishness when all hope seems lost. This conflict is demonstrated in the lyrics through the prominent use of antithesis. The first lines of the song, “Wasting your time / your wasting mine” (Soot 0:30-0:40) convey this motif of hopelessness through the antithesis in the parallel structure. The first part of the sentence reflects the frustration that accompanies being afflicted with a mental disorder. Not only is it causing personal struggles, but due to the lack of accessible health care, people are being robbed of the opportunity to better their quality of life, hence their time is being wasted. On the other hand, the antithesis reflects the hopelessness of being in said situation. While most people strive to take action and fight for accessible opportunities, in reality, it's extremely difficult to make change with the systematic issues and ignorance in our society. This represents how striving for change can feel like wasted time as well. These systematic roadblocks are the main focus of this song, with Soot stating how our

convoluted societal structures continue to perpetuate the mental illness epidemic. One way he reflects this is in the third verse, where he directs the audience to “shout at the wall” (Soot 1:34-1:37) because the walls don’t love them. This is a metaphor for protesting these systematic issues, with the walls representing the government, the legislature, and the ignorance that perpetuates the inescapability, stigma, and lack of awareness that is profuse throughout our society. By encouraging the audience to “shout at the wall”, Soot calls for action and protest of the aspects of our society that don't love us.

At the end of the song, Soot repeats “There's a reason, London puts barriers on the tube line / There’s a reason, London puts barriers on the rails” (Soot 2:22-2:57) five times. This repetition is used to express the feeling of insanity that attaches to the efforts of trying and trying to no avail. Whether that is trying to change systematic issues, trying to obtain a diagnosis or proper treatment, trying to support a loved one suffering from a mental disorder, or trying to just survive each day, the repetition can feel maddening and entrapping. With this repetition impacting so many people, the desire for change becomes more and more desired. This then transitions into the message behind these lyrics, the temporary solution that is enacted to quiet the desire for change. Soot is implying that the reason that “London puts barriers on the tube line” is to prevent people from committing suicide by jumping onto the train tracks. However, during the final repetition of the line, Soot yet again uses antithesis by writing “There’s a reason, they fail.” (Soot 2:53-2:57) This change in the parallel structure implies that not only are the solutions inadequate, but by shortening the number of syllables in the line, it implies that they are short and temporary. This final line is also an aphorism for the message of the song, the failure of the barriers representing the systematic failures of our society.

One of the most significant lines in this song is the line “Your city gave me asthma”. (Soot 1:09-1:11) Not only is the album named after this line, but it displays an effective message in the context of mental health. While the obvious assumption is to associate this line with concepts such as pollution or industrialism, Soot’s use of asthma is an allusion to a way of thinking related to mental health. This way of thinking surrounds the political aspect of mental health, a motif that Soot clearly illustrates throughout his work. The idea is that asthma occurs at a disproportionately higher rate in low-income communities, like sink estates, communities that are located in areas with higher pollution, waste, or industrial outputs. (Shade) Due to these low-income communities being exposed to these elements, there becomes a statistical increase in asthma in minority groups. The politics behind this thought process apply to the mental health crisis as well. Low-income communities and groups that are exposed to more toxic and stressful environments develop mental disorders disproportionately more than upper-class citizens. These political structures jeopardize minority groups and lower-income citizens, and unless changed, will continue to expose people to toxic environments and situations, henceforth perpetuating the epidemic.

3. *I’m Sorry Boris*

“I’m Sorry Boris” is the final track on “Your City Gave Me Asthma” and it serves as a beautiful conclusion to the story and the message that Wilbur Soot has been conveying throughout his music. It balances all the elements from the previous songs, the motifs of government, mental health, ignorance, materialistic distractions, and hopelessness, while solemnly explaining how the narrator manages to make peace with these ideas. Soot begins to

describe how he's "figured out what can move me" (Soot 1:06-1:11) and lists materialistic goods such as trains and sushi. This implies how regardless of his moral beliefs, he cannot make effective change. This is reiterated with the aphorism and the end of the verse, "I'm not good for anyone here." (Soot 1:30-1:34) These lines are symbolic of how disheartening these systematic structures can be for people. They oppress minorities, purposefully promote ignorance with consumerism, and perpetuate these disorders by exposing ourselves, our friends, our family, and our loved ones to harmful and devastating circumstances. Soot mirrors this in the line "My lovers, my colleagues, my best friends and enemies" (Soot 3:30-3:38), and utilizes the anaphora of "my" to emphasize to the audience that this is an epidemic that impacts everyone. Similar to "Jubilee Line", Soot includes a verse with repetition that includes an antithesis in the parallel structure. He goes from repeating how he can't believe he's leaving, to saying he doesn't think he wants to leave. This also parallels another line in "Jubilee Line" where he states "I hate to see you leaving" (Soot 0:43-0:46). This represents the cyclical structure of these systematic roadblocks, how eventually it discourages one person, and then the other.

The most prominent part of this song is certainly the fourth verse. It consists of four parallel lines, each highlighting a way these systematic structures fail to help the struggling members of our society. He writes, "They'll charge for your healthcare before helping you / They'll make you jump under trains before helping you" (Soot 3:02-3:14). These lines perfectly condense and emulate the purposeful ignorance that is continuing to negatively impact our communities and perpetuate this mental health epidemic. Not only does he allude again to "Jubilee Line" again with the mention of trains, but he also continues with the motif of vague pronoun references, by challenging the audience to question whether or not it's directly the

government, the workers, or the citizens who are perpetuating these systems, similarly to the use of “ramblers” in “The Fall”. It leaves the audience debating whether or not the uneducated are blameable, as they perpetuate these systems subconsciously. He illustrates this moral dilemma throughout most of his music, and in the last verse states that he's “finished” (Soot 3:18), even though he’s “not quite done with it” (Soot 3:20-3:23) symbolizing how he has given up fighting these structures, even though he knows it is still an issue.

The song is titled “I’m Sorry Boris”, in reference to the former British prime minister, Boris Johnson. Including the allusion to Boris Johnson not only conveys the ignorance and incompetence that government representatives introduce into the already convoluted systems, but also reflects the extreme disconnect between those who are aware and affected by the issue, and those who benefit from the oppressive societal structures. In July of 2019, Boris released a statement declaring that the solution to the mental health crisis was to “work hard.” (Mahdawi) He explained that the satisfaction from completing work-related tasks is what drives self-esteem and mental positivity. (Mahdawi) This severe lack of understanding between the citizens affected by these structures and the mental health epidemic and the leaders who have the resources to encourage change is an incredibly prominent aspect that perpetuates these systematic issues. It's what continues to discourage people like Soot, making people feel like they are “not good for anyone here”, henceforth damaging their self-esteem and introducing a sense of mental negativity, one that can’t just be worked away. Why try for change when the people who actually can influence change don't care? Soot illustrates this in “I’m Sorry Boris”, as he describes how he feels guilt about giving up, how he feels hopeless, and how he eventually comes to peace with himself, understanding that these systems are designed to perpetuate these issues.

On the other hand, there's evidence of authoritative action toward positive mental health legislation, so perhaps Soot is viewing all of this from a pessimistic perspective. In just the last few months, the UK government produced a consultation regarding mental wellness and the changes that need to be made for systematic improvement. It calls for citizens to be “ambitious” in their suggestions, with the intention that the results will be influential towards a 10-year plan to support citizens' mental well-being and “refresh the strategy for suicide prevention in England.” (Weatherhead) This consultation is a positive step in the right direction, so maybe Soot’s regret for the lack of purposeful action is unnecessary, and maybe our society isn't as hopeless as Soot portrays in his music. However, when the National Health Services (NHS) in England collaborated with the UK government to dictate 9 policy commitments for the government to implement, only 1 of the 9 commitments was scored as “Good” when reviewed later. The other 8 commitments were marked as “Requires Improvement”, displaying how the government had failed to adequately adhere to its commitments. (“The Government's Response”) So whereas there may be some evidence regarding positive change towards systematic issues, there is still a lot that needs to be addressed and taken seriously in order to encourage positive change.

Conclusion

While Wilbur Soot may be a YouTuber who creates goofy Minecraft videos and unique comedy songs, he is able to encapsulate challenging ideas through his writing in a way that undoubtedly positively impacts his audience. He uses his platform to educate those on important issues and describe individual perspectives in a way that is entertaining and engaging, even to the average 12-year-old Minecraft YouTube viewer. Soot is able to use repetition, parallelism, rhyme schemes, allusions, and much more to describe how systematic ignorance perpetuates the mental health crisis that our world is experiencing. He illustrates the mental toll that these systems have on those affected by them, how seeking change can be continuously disheartening, and how incredibly enticing yet conflicting it can be when these systems are perfectly designed to encourage ignorance. His music is helping bring awareness to these issues and validate the struggle that countless people are going through. The mental health crisis is still an epidemic, regardless of the indie songs that video game YouTuber writes about it. But Wilbur Soot eloquently translates these scary, existential, and depressing ideas into enjoyable and meaningful music.

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